

Creative Funding Toolkit – ACE Edition (v1.0)

Purpose: This streamlined toolkit is designed for individual artists applying for Arts Council England (ACE) Project Grants in 2026. It distils the core steps, provides practical templates and reflects UK funding realities without jargon or hype.

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How to use this toolkit

This guide is for independent artists and freelancers who are preparing an ACE Project Grants application. It explains what ACE looks for, helps you decide if an opportunity is right, shows how to plan and describe your project, and gives you tools to budget, manage risks and evaluate your work. Use the quick-start checklist when you're short of time, then dive into the relevant sections as needed. The appendices list additional resources and rate guides.

Quick-start checklist

1. **Check your eligibility** – confirm you meet ACE's requirements (you are based in England, have a valid bank account, and your activity is arts-related and public-facing).
2. **Select the right pot** – ACE Project Grants support creation and development projects; DYCP supports individual practice. Choose the one that aligns with your goals.
3. **Define your idea** – summarise your project in one sentence; articulate why it matters now and who it serves.
4. **Research your funder** – read the Project Grants guidance; note priorities around public engagement, diversity, equity and environmental responsibility.
5. **Sketch your plan** – outline activities, timeline, roles and outputs; identify risks and how you'll mitigate them.
6. **Draft your budget** – list costs using current day rates; include in-kind contributions and match funding if applicable; ensure income equals expenditure.
7. **Write your answers** – address each ACE question clearly: need, outcomes, public benefit, management, governance and finance. Use examples.

8. **Review and edit** – ask a peer to sense-check; ensure your narrative, budget and timeline align; check spelling and formatting.
9. **Submit and track** – submit before the deadline; note the decision date; log your application details in a tracker.
10. **Reflect and recycle** – whether you win or not, record feedback, update your templates and refine for next time.

Deciding whether to apply

Before investing time in a bid, take a moment to assess fit and readiness:

- **Is this fund aligned?** Read the fund's aims. If your project does not clearly support them, look elsewhere.
- **Do you have a clear idea?** Write one sentence explaining what you will do, who it is for and why it matters.
- **Can you commit time?** ACE applications take several hours to prepare. Make sure you can focus without burning out.
- **Do you have rough costs?** You don't need an exact budget yet, but you should know the scale of your project and whether it's realistic.
- **Will it help your practice?** ACE wants to fund development, not emergency cashflow. Ensure your project contributes to your long-term artistic goals.

If you answer “no” to more than one of these points, postpone or pivot. Funding is not a trophy; it should serve your practice, not the other way around.

Understanding ACE and other funders

ACE Project Grants focus on projects that benefit the public and develop the applicant's practice. Key points:

- **Eligibility:** Individuals, collectives and organisations based in England can apply. You need a UK bank account, a track record in the arts, and a project that is time-limited and publicly accessible.
- **Funding size:** Grants range from £1,000 to £100,000. Applications up to £30k have a shorter form; above £30k require more detail and take longer.
- **Match funding:** ACE expects you to contribute financially or in kind, but there is no fixed percentage. Demonstrating commitment and realism strengthens your bid.
- **Assessment criteria:** ACE assesses quality (artistic merit and ambition), public engagement (audience definition and access), finance (viability and value for money), management (skills and track record) and environmental responsibility.
- **Timeline:** Decisions typically take eight weeks for small grants and twelve weeks for larger ones. Plan your project start date accordingly.

Other funders (e.g., Heritage Lottery Fund, BFI, PRS) have different priorities and forms. Research them separately and adapt your language. If you're unsure which pot to pursue, compare eligibility, award sizes and priorities before drafting an application.

Planning your project

Good planning underpins a strong application. Use the following tools and templates:

Project summary

Write a short paragraph covering:

- **What** you will create or deliver.
- **Who** it is for (define your primary and secondary audiences).
- **Why** it matters now (context, demand, opportunity).
- **How** you will deliver it (activities, partners, venues, platforms).

Objectives and outcomes

Break down your project into objectives (what you intend to achieve) and outcomes (the change you expect). Use a logic model:

Inputs	Activities	Outputs	Outcomes
People, time, equipment, funding	Rehearsals, workshops, performances, digital production	Number of events, participants, artworks produced	Increased skills, knowledge, visibility; audience engagement; enhanced reputation

Timeline

Create a simple Gantt chart or timeline with these columns: task, start date, end date, responsible person and dependencies. Example tasks might include R&D, creation, marketing, rehearsals, performances and evaluation. Make sure the timeline aligns with your budget and resources.

Audience and access

Identify who will engage with your work. Describe their demographics, interests and barriers to access. Outline how you will remove those barriers (e.g., affordable pricing, captioning, BSL interpretation, accessible venues, online options). ACE prioritises work that reaches diverse audiences and addresses under-served communities.

Partners and collaborators

List any partners, collaborators or mentors. Briefly explain their role and confirm whether they are confirmed or prospective. Attaching letters of support strengthens your application.

Writing your application

ACE's online form asks specific questions. Here are key sections and how to approach them:

1. **About your project.** Summarise the project clearly. Avoid jargon. Mention what makes it distinctive and how it relates to your practice.

2. **Artistic quality.** Explain the artistic vision and why it is compelling. Reference previous work or research that informs your approach.
3. **Public engagement.** Define your audience and describe how you will reach and involve them. Include access measures and outreach plans.
4. **Management and partners.** Demonstrate your capability to deliver: outline roles, highlight relevant experience, and show that partners are committed.
5. **Finance.** Provide a balanced budget (see next section) and justify significant costs. Mention any match funding or in-kind support.
6. **Outcomes and evaluation.** Describe the difference your project will make and how you will measure success. Link outcomes to your logic model.
7. **Environmental responsibility.** Explain steps you will take to minimise environmental impact (e.g., travel planning, digital delivery, recycling materials).

Sample answer (public engagement)

Our primary audience is young adults (18–30) in Leicester who have limited access to live dance. We will collaborate with local youth centres and host two open workshops to co-create choreography. Performances will be free and streamed online with BSL interpretation. We will gather feedback via post-show discussions and a short survey to measure engagement and learning.

Budgeting and finance

A convincing budget is clear, realistic and balanced. Follow these steps:

1. **List expenditure** – break down costs by category: artist fees, project management, marketing and access, materials and equipment, travel and subsistence, documentation, evaluation, overheads and contingency (5–10 %). Use current day rates; consult Equity, MU, ITC and BECTU rate guides.
2. **List income** – include the ACE grant you’re requesting, your own contribution (cash or in kind), and any other grants, sponsorship or earned income. Match funding is not mandatory but strengthens your application.
3. **Balance the budget** – total income must equal total expenditure. ACE expects budgets to balance unless you explain a surplus or deficit.
4. **Justify key costs** – for each significant item, provide a short explanation. For example, “Artist fee covers 10 days of rehearsal at £250/day”, or “Contingency set at 8 % to cover unforeseen venue costs”.
5. **Include in-kind support** – if a venue waives hire fees or a mentor volunteers time, assign a realistic value and list it under income and expenditure.

Sample budget (summary)

Item	Cost (£)	Notes
Artist/creator fees	2,500	10 days at £250/day
Project management	1,000	Administrative coordination and reporting

Item	Cost (£)	Notes
Marketing & access	800	Social media, printed flyers, BSL interpreter
Materials & equipment	600	Props, costume, software licences
Travel & subsistence	400	Local travel and refreshments
Evaluation	300	Survey design, data analysis
Overheads	400	Studio hire, insurance
Contingency (8 %)	560	Buffer for unforeseen costs
Total expenditure	6,560	
ACE grant requested	5,560	
Match funding (cash)	500	Contribution from local sponsor
In-kind support	500	Free rehearsal space valued at £25/hour
Total income	6,560	

Risk, evaluation and compliance

Risk register

Create a simple risk log to show you have considered potential problems. Include risk, likelihood, impact, mitigation and responsible person. Example:

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation	Owner
Lead artist illness delays rehearsals	Medium	High	Identify a qualified understudy; build contingency days into the schedule	Project manager
Venue becomes unavailable	Low	High	Secure a secondary venue and confirm booking terms early	Producer
Budget overruns on marketing	Medium	Medium	Get quotes in advance and prioritise cost-effective channels	Administrator

Evaluation plan

ACE wants evidence that your project makes a difference. Outline:

- **What you will measure:** attendance numbers, participant demographics, feedback scores, skill gains.
- **How you will collect data:** sign-in sheets, online surveys, observation, interviews.
- **When you will collect it:** at events, after events and at the project's end.
- **Who will analyse it:** yourself or a designated evaluator.

Use your logic model to link outputs (e.g., number of workshops) to outcomes (e.g., participants' increased confidence) and impact (e.g., wider community engagement).

Safeguarding, EDI and legal compliance

- **Safeguarding:** If your project involves children or vulnerable adults, outline your safeguarding policy and confirm DBS checks where appropriate.
- **Equality, diversity and inclusion:** Demonstrate how your project will reach diverse groups and remove barriers. Reference the Public Sector Equality Duty and provide specific actions (e.g., collaborating with diverse partners, commissioning BSL interpretation).
- **Environmental responsibility:** Describe steps to minimise environmental impact (e.g., using local suppliers, minimising travel, recycling materials).
- **Legal essentials:** Confirm your legal status (self-employed/sole trader), ownership of intellectual property, insurance coverage (public liability), data protection compliance (GDPR) and whether you are registered for VAT.

Submitting and aftercare

- **Before submission:** Review each answer against the ACE guidance. Double-check your budget balances and that attachments are uploaded. Ask a colleague to proofread.
- **Submit on time:** Upload your application through the ACE Grantium system before the deadline. Note the submission date and estimated decision date.
- **Track your applications:** Keep a simple tracker with fields for fund name, amount requested, submission date, decision date, outcome and notes. Use this to schedule follow-ups and plan future bids.
- **If successful:** Celebrate, then follow ACE's conditions. Keep receipts and records; submit progress and final reports on time. Deliver the project as described or agree changes in advance.
- **If unsuccessful:** Record feedback; note any patterns (e.g., repeated comments about unclear outcomes). Save strong answers for future applications. Don't take rejection personally; it reflects funder priorities and capacity.

Building a sustainable funding practice

Funding should support your practice, not drain it. Develop habits to make applications easier and more strategic:

- **Template everything:** Maintain a library of bios, CVs, project summaries and budgets that you can adapt quickly.
- **Track deadlines:** Subscribe to newsletters and set calendar alerts. Use an annual planner to note when major pots typically open.
- **Create a best-answers bank:** Collect phrases and paragraphs from successful applications and repurpose them with tweaks.
- **Set boundaries:** Decide what you will apply for (e.g., minimum grant size, thematic alignment) to avoid scatter-gun submissions.
- **Reflect regularly:** Every few months, review which bids landed and why. Adjust your approach based on feedback and changes in the funding landscape.

Appendices and further reading

- **Rate guides:** Equity (performers), Musicians' Union, Independent Theatre Council, BECTU (technical crew), a-n (visual artists).
 - **Funding bodies:** Arts Council England (Project Grants and DYCP), National Lottery Heritage Fund, British Film Institute (BFI), PRS Foundation, Film & TV Charity.
 - **Evaluation resources:** NCVO Charities Evaluation Services; Julie's Bicycle (environmental reporting); CultureHive (case studies).
 - **Access and inclusion:** Shape Arts guidelines on inclusive events; Arts Council's Creative Case for Diversity.
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This ACE-focused toolkit was drafted using human expertise, lived experience and digital tools. It reflects the funding environment as of late 2025; always verify details on funders' websites before applying.